

Student Negotiations of Authorship and Ethics in AI-Assisted Visual Production: A Case Study of Undergraduate Film Education at the Department of Drama, Cinema and Television, University of Kelaniya

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Background and Context

Key Points

- Generative AI is increasingly influencing creative higher education.
- Film students use AI for scriptwriting, mood boards, visualization, editing, and post-production.
- AI is reshaping creative learning and production practices.
- Universities have yet to establish clear ethical and pedagogical guidance for AI use.

This study explores how undergraduate film students negotiate authorship and ethical responsibility when AI becomes part of creative production.

Research Problem and Gap

Research Problem	Research Gap
Students are adopting AI faster than institutional policies	Limited evidence from Sri Lankan higher education.
Ethical decision making is often left to individual students	Little research on AI-assisted film education.
Existing research focuses mainly on Western educational contexts.	Students' perspectives remain underexplored.

Aim, Objectives and Research Questions

Research Aim
• To explore how undergraduate film students negotiate authorship, creativity, and ethical responsibility when using AI assisted visual production tools.

Research Questions
• How are AI tools used throughout visual production?
• How do students understand authorship and originality?
• What ethical tensions do students experience?
• How does the institutional environment shape responsible AI use?

Methodology

Design
•Planned qualitative case study

Study Site
• Department of Drama, Cinema and Television, University of Kelaniya

Participants
• 20–25 second- and third-year undergraduate students
• Purposive sampling

Data Collection and Analysis

Data Collection
•Semi-structured interviews
•Focus group discussions
•Document analysis

Data Analysis
• Thematic Analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006)
• Inductive coding
• Theme development

Ethical Considerations
• Ethical approval
• Informed consent
• Confidentiality
• Voluntary participation

Expected Outcomes **(Planned Study – No empirical findings yet)**

The study anticipates that students may

- Use AI throughout multiple stages of filmmaking.
- Develop personal ethical boundaries.
- Experience uncertainty regarding acceptable AI use.
- Distinguish between AI as a creative support tool and AI as a replacement for creative decision-making.

Anticipated Findings

- AI-supported creativity
- Ethical ambiguity
- Negotiating authorship
- Originality and ownership
- Institutional preparedness
- Curriculum and assessment gaps

Discussion

Theoretical
Extends authorship theory to AI-assisted creative practice.
Educational
Supports AI literacy and ethical reasoning in creative education.
Institutional
Highlights the need for curriculum redesign and clearer AI guidance.
Cultural
Provides a non-Western perspective on AI-assisted learning.

Conclusions

Key Takeaways
• AI is reshaping creative learning environments.
• Students require institutional support to navigate ethical AI use.
• Responsible AI integration should become part of film education.
• This study contributes a Sri Lankan perspective to global discussions on AI in higher education.

Future Directions
• Obtain ethical clearance.
• Conduct fieldwork in late 2026.
• Expand research to other creative disciplines.

Thank you for your attention.

"***The future of creative education depends not only on adopting AI, but on teaching students to use it ethically, critically, and creatively***."